Jet Fuel Hits a Record High -- and Holiday Plane Tickets Cost More

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Planning to fly somewhere for the holidays? Your ticket will probably cost more this year a lot more.

The reason is **jet fuel**, the special fuel airplanes burn. It is one of the biggest costs airlines have, and its price just hit a record. On Thursday, the average price of **jet fuel** in the United States reached $4.90 a gallon, according to the tracking firm Argus. That is the highest one-day average the firm has ever recorded and more than twice what it cost a year ago.

Airlines are passing part of that cost on to passengers. "**Airfares** right now are at what we see as a 10-year high because of the high cost of **jet fuel**," said Hayley Berg, the lead **economist** at Hopper, a travel company. Tickets for Thanksgiving trips are up about 30% compared with last year, she said, and Christmas tickets are up more than 20%.

Surprisingly, people are still buying. Delta Air Lines CEO Ed Bastian said travelers have shown only a "limited amount of resistance" and still see flying as reasonably affordable. Berg says holiday travel is "sticky": families really want to get home or take their big trip, so most are not canceling.

Airlines say they are **absorbing** most of the extra fuel cost themselves and passing only some of it to customers. Even so, some travelers are changing plans. One Maryland traveler said tickets for her whole family cost too much, so she will drive to Chicago instead.

And the shoppers who are flying are hunting for deals: Berg says many people booked their holiday trips earlier than usual this year, hoping to lock in a **fare** before prices climb even higher.

Word Treasure

jet fuel -- The special fuel that airplanes burn to fly.

airfares -- The prices people pay for plane tickets.

economist -- A person who studies how money, prices and jobs work.

absorbing -- Taking on a cost yourself instead of passing it all to someone else.

fare -- The price paid to travel on a plane, bus or train.

Background you need

Jet fuel is the special fuel that jet airplanes burn, and buying it is one of the biggest costs an airline has.

When fuel gets more expensive, airlines often raise ticket prices, because they pass part of the extra cost on to passengers.

The end of the year is one of the busiest times to fly, as families travel for Thanksgiving and Christmas.

Because so many people want to fly at the same time, holiday tickets are often among the most expensive of the year.

Break it down

LEAD: A record jet fuel price is pushing holiday airfares to a 10-year high

KEY EVENT: Jet fuel averages $4.90 a gallon, the highest one-day average Argus has ever recorded

+- WHO: Airlines pass part of the cost to passengers; Hopper economist Hayley Berg tracks the fares

+- WHEN: Reported this week, ahead of the Thanksgiving and Christmas travel season

EVIDENCE: Thanksgiving fares are up about 30% and Christmas fares more than 20% versus last year

OPEN QUESTION: Whether fares climb even higher before the holidays arrive

Why it matters

Fuel is one of the biggest costs of flying, so when its price jumps, holiday trips and family visits become more expensive for everyone. Even so, most travelers are still booking, which shows how much people value getting home for the holidays.

Test what you remember

1. What did the average price of jet fuel in the U.S. reach on Thursday?

- (A) $4.90 a gallon
- (B) $2.45 a gallon
- (C) $3.10 a gallon
- (D) $9.40 a gallon

2. Who said airfares are at a 10-year high because of jet fuel costs?

- (A) The head of Airlines for America
- (B) A Delta Air Lines pilot
- (C) Hayley Berg, lead economist at Hopper
- (D) A travel agent in Baltimore

3. By about how much are Thanksgiving airfares up compared with last year?

- (A) About 60%
- (B) About 15%
- (C) About 5%
- (D) About 30%

4. How did Delta's CEO describe travelers' reaction to the higher fares?

- (A) A rush to buy even more tickets
- (B) Mass cancellations
- (C) A limited amount of resistance
- (D) Angry protests at airports

5. What did one Maryland traveler decide to do because tickets cost too much?

- (A) Drive to Chicago instead of flying
- (B) Take a train to Florida
- (C) Skip the holidays entirely
- (D) Fly on Christmas Day itself

6. What did many shoppers do differently when booking this year?

- (A) They waited for last-minute deals
- (B) They switched to smaller airports
- (C) They booked earlier than usual to lock in a fare
- (D) They only bought refundable tickets

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: C 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Hayley Berg, Hopper economist: Fares are at a 10-year high because of fuel costs, but holiday travel is 'sticky' and most people are not canceling.

2. Ed Bastian, Delta Air Lines CEO: Travelers have shown only a limited amount of resistance and still see airfare as reasonably affordable.

3. Airlines, as described in the article: They are absorbing most of the extra fuel cost themselves and passing only some of it on to customers.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):